MAN IN CHARGE
TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee addresses the martyr's day rally in Kolkata on July 21

aggressive BJP was hot on the TMC's heels with a 40 per cent vote share and 18 out of Bengal's 42 seats, it was Abhishek who suggested roping in poll strategist Prashant Kishor for the 2021 assembly election. They acted with a full awareness of how, at the ground level, extortion, cut money and high-handedness had alienated voters in 2019. Kishor, on cue, suggested that one-third of party MLAs be dropped to wash off the spreading stain of corruption—that was in sync with Abhishek's line. And it paid off handsomely.

After that hard-fought win, Abhishek came to have a greater say over cabinet posts. He made sure some ministers who had been clinging on to multiple portfolios like so many fiefdoms were shuffled around, even if he couldn't fully implement his 'one-person-one-post' policy. In his quiet way, Abhishek also pushed the young brigade to take up the party's reins in the districts. Face-offs with the old guard ensued, and Mamata often intervened on behalf of the loyalists. Abhishek bade his time. The opportune moment, say insiders, came with Chatterjee's arrest.

In a way, this is a natural evolution for the TMC: of arriving at a point where it looks for a life beyond Mamata, sustained by something more systemic than her larger-than-life cult persona. Abhishek seeks it, for now, in an ethos built around transparent governance and energetic performers. Says Jawhar Sircar, TMC Rajya Sabha MP, "Like all non-cadre parties, TMC can be a bit amorphous. Abhishek is trying to instal a pyramidal set-up."

Abhishek played a big role in the August 3 cabinet rejig, necessitated by Chatterjee's ouster. Four of the eight new faces—Partha Bhowmik, Snehasish Chakrabarty, Babul Supriyo and Udayan Guha—are close to him. And when they took oath, they thanked both Mamata and Abhishek. "He doesn't suffer from political romanticism, but brings acumen and foresight into party management," says Rajya Sabha MP Sukhendu Shekhar Ray. "His decisions are based on professional inputs and curated data, not caprice," adds Sircar. Abhishek's political nous has been appreciated by Mamata too. Its hallmark is prudence, not grandstanding: it was he who advised Mamata to attend the NITI Aayog meet in Delhi in early August and not clash with the Centre—she had skipped last year's virtual meet.

As if to sum all this up, a new TMC poster has appeared in Kolkata with Abhishek's image, with the legend: "New Trinamool in six months, like people want". Another poster calls Mamata the foundation (*bhitti*) and Abhishek the future (*bhobishyot*). Over the past week, his personal office on Camac Street has seen more party people trooping in—prepping for the panchayat polls, due in early 2023—than at party HQ Trinamool Bhawan.

Abhishek has learnt, too, from Mamata's tools of connecting with the public. At the martyr's day rally on July 21, he stood at the mic in pouring rain, soaked to the skin. The huge crowd cheered him on, as much for what he had to say as for the spectacle of the future supremo as a common man caught in a downpour. It was a moment of mass identification. ■

HIMACHAL PRADESH/ ASSEMBLY POLL

THE HARD TREK TO SHIMLA

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

The Congress's state-wide Yuva Rozgar Yatra started from Himachal Pradesh's winter capital Dharamshala in end-July, a soft launch of the party campaign for the assembly election in November. In the run-up to it, party sources claimed internal differences had been ironed out and sought to project a sense of unity. Not such an easy task, though, when the state unit's steering committee was itself headed by a member of the famous G-23 group of rebels: former Union minister Anand Sharma. On August 21, Sharma quit that post protesting "continued exclusion and insults". Six days later, he left the local unit on tenterhooks as he met Ghulam Nabi Azad, the latest high-profile escapee from the party, on the eve of a crucial CWC meeting in Delhi. With the state's most recognised face in central politics himself looking edgy, the party's Himachal in-charge, AICC secretary Rajiv Shukla, has his hands full.

Not that local politics is affording him any sense of serenity. Balancing power equations in the Himachal Congress is essentially about continuing to draw sustenance from the 60-year-old legacy of the late Virbhadra Singh while keeping other factions in good humour. The six-time CM had always managed to quell factionalism with a firm grip on the old Himachal regions of Mandi, Kullu, Kangra, Shimla, Solan and Sirmaur. In 2017, as many as 13 of the party's 21 MLAs came from these districts. In November 2021, riding a sympathy wave after his death, the Congress had swept bypolls to three assembly seats and the Mandi Lok